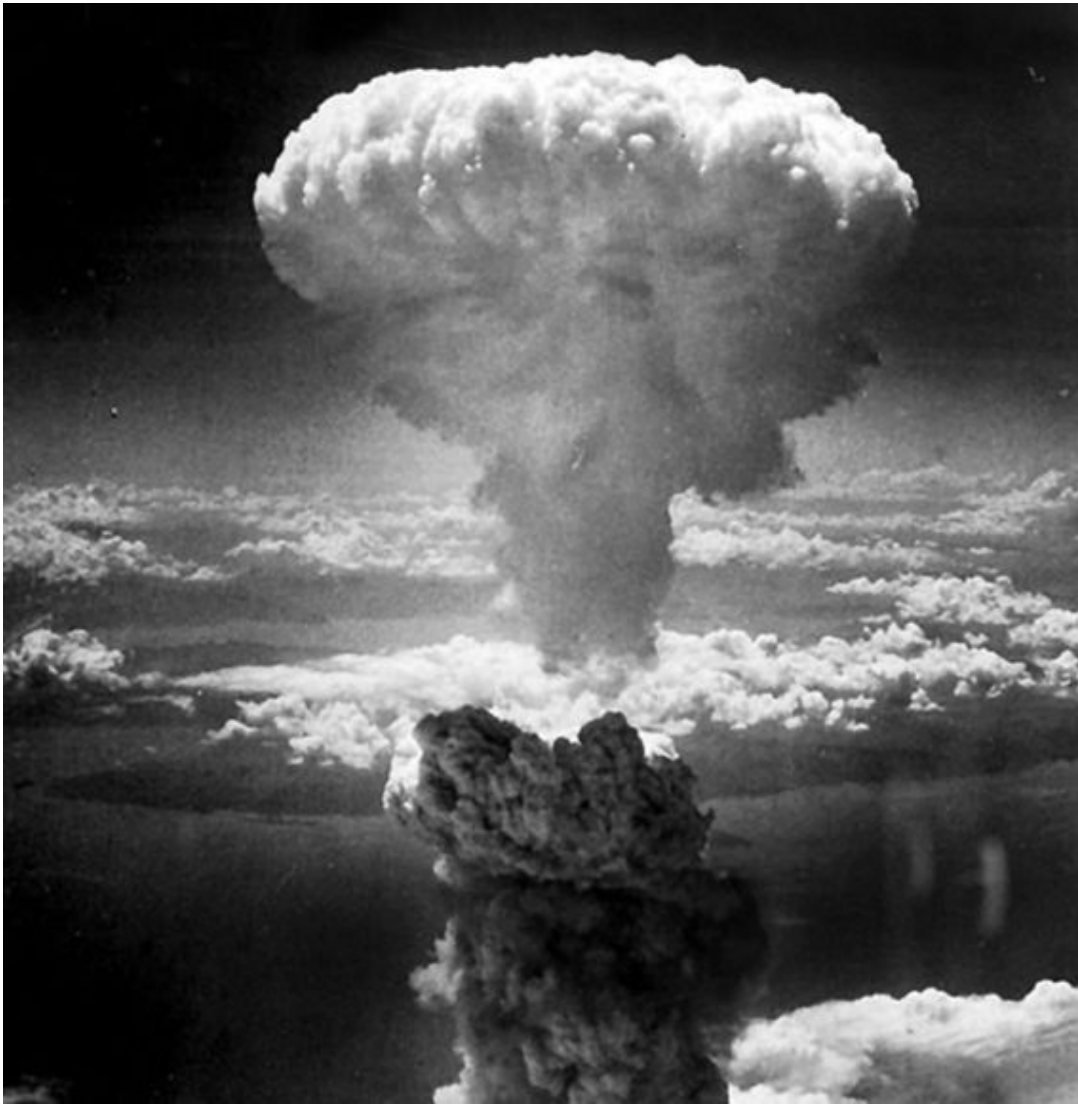


Ends and means



Was the Allied use of atomic bombs in 1945 justified as a means of accelerating the end of the Second World War?

One of the implicit messages of the political realism in Machiavelli's *The Prince* was that 'the end justifies the means'. This marked a significant shift in political philosophy, and subsequently in moral philosophy as a whole, to judging an action's morality on its consequences rather than intentions or motives. As a result of Renaissance humanism, morally correct conduct was no longer dictated by religious authority, and ideas of good and evil were

not as absolute as those of Christian doctrine. Political philosophy could similarly not be based on an ideal structure for society. Consequentialism, the notion that results are the basis for judging the rightness of conduct, became a prevalent approach in moral philosophy from the Renaissance into the Enlightenment, influencing the utilitarianism of the late 18th and early 19th centuries (see [Bentham and utilitarianism](#)). It was not until Immanuel Kant proposed his deontological (duty-based) system of moral philosophy (see [The categorical imperative](#)) that emphasis shifted from consequences to motives and intentions as a basis for moral judgements.